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Depiction of Bromance Relationships in the Media:

A Theoretical Analysis of *Jersey Shore*

Tara Powell

Northeastern University

Introduction

In an age of deep entanglement with broadcast and digital media, the media, as a whole, has a unique ability to convey societal norms and practices to mass amounts of people. The Social Cognitive Theory affirms that people tend to gain knowledge on how to behave through observation, imitation and modeling (Bandura 1994). Thus, the media has the ability to shape the mass understanding of society, including the issues and realities that lay within it. Consequently, media's relationship between modeled and learned behavior creates an opportunity to either maintain or reconstruct dogmas within society. Hollywood has begun to use such an opportunity to create a new construction of masculinity through comedic "bromance" relationships depicted in films and television shows.

The term "bromance" was coined around 2004 and refers to a close relationship between two straight males (Alberti, 2013). The popular MTV reality television, *Jersey Shore*, is one source of media that illustrates a bromance relationship amidst a culture of partying, hook ups, pranks and drama. Pauly D and Vinny first met on the show and their friendship has evolved throughout the seasons, reboots, and spin-offs. Due to the popularity of the show, Vinny and Pauly D's bromance is well known throughout pop culture from memes and gifs to youtube videos and twitter posts. Vinny and Pauly D's close friendship highlights the ability for bromance relationships to reconstruct rigid notions of masculinity by incorporating a wider variety of characteristics for a relationship, such as intimacy and affection. However, bromances have been critiqued for spreading the phenomenon of "straight panic," where straight males are overly concerned that their actions will be misconstrued as homosexual behavior (Hammaren & Johansson, 2014). The Homosocial Theory, which studies non-sexual relationships between two

individuals of the same sex, explains these two opposite outcomes of bromance relationships: masculinity reconstruction and straight panic. Nevertheless, the rise of bromance depictions in the media suggests an oncoming shift in societal notions of masculinity. In particular, Alberti identifies the incorporation of bromance relationships into the entertainment industry as a “key moment in its evolutionary development” (Alberti, 2013).

The purpose of this study is to further our knowledge on the dynamics of bromance relationships. Through the lens of the Social Penetration Theory, this paper identifies whether the obstacles that bromance relationships face differ from other relationships in regards to development and maintenance. The Social Penetration Theory holds that the development of meaningful relationships hinges of the breadth and depth of interactions. On a larger scale, this paper explores whether bromance relationships alter the construction of masculinity, especially in the media because television is a provider of content which is observed and later modeled via the Social Cognitive Theory.

Literature Review

Construction of Masculinity

The concept of masculinity pulls together certain characteristics and attributes of men, which then provides a standard for how men should behave in society (Kaya, Iwamoto, Brady, Clinton & Grivel, 2019). Masculinity has also been referred to as a “performance” within society (Sargent 2013). It is important to note that masculinity is a social construction of gender roles and, therefore, changes from culture to culture and throughout time. In western culture, society has constructed and perpetuated a rigid type of masculinity which has coined the name marketplace or hegemonic masculinity (Kiesling, 2005; Rothenberg, 2016). Hegemonic

masculinity refers to characteristics such as aggression, competition, dominance, status-driven, emotional restrictiveness, emphasis on having many sexual partners, and risk-taking (Sargent, 2013; Rothenberg, 2016). Here, manhood lives in a marketplace where the title of a ‘real man’ is granted through measurements of success, power, and wealth (Rothenberg, 2016). Hegemonic masculinity enforces the notion that masculinity is the polar opposite of femininity and when men tread in a territory outside of masculine norms, they are risking their behavior to be marked as feminine. Being labeled feminine is one of the most important rules for men to follow to maintain their status and identity as a strong man (Kiesling, 2005). Additionally, hegemonic masculinity is closely associated with heterosexism, which places a requirement of heterosexuality on masculinity (Kiesling, 2005).

There is a concern that when such rigid notions of gender roles are endorsed, especially in young men, it will affect an individual’s wellbeing, specifically one’s: “self-acceptance, purpose in life, personal growth, and positive relationships” (Kaya et al., 2019). In particular, a study found that men who express trademark characteristics of marketplace masculinity, such as emotional restrictiveness and the need for success, have lower well-being and mental health (Kaya et al., 2019). Conversely, it is important to note that certain characteristics of masculinity, such as risk-taking, reinforce favorable behaviors such as independence and bravery (Hammer & Good, 2010).

The feminist, civil rights, and gay movement’s confrontation of a targeted group of men who have allocated the status of manhood has since led to questions regarding the validity of hegemonic masculinity (Sargent, 2013). African-Americans, women and the LGBTQ community challenged the power assigned to white, heterosexual men. As a result, the men’s movement has

attempted to solidify a definition of manhood amidst a rise of the previously subordinate minorities such as women, African-Americans and the LGBTQ community. Thus, Diana Sargent refers to this flux in gender roles as a “crisis” in the construction of masculinity (Sargent, 2013).

Homosocial Theory and Bromances

Homosociality explains nonsexual relationships between individuals of the same sex (Hammeren & Johansson, 2014). Specifically, homosocial theory refers to the study of how males bond with each other, set boundaries, and the amount of inclusive relations incorporated such as emotional closeness and intimacy (Hammeren & Johansson, 2014). A friendship between two individuals relies on the ability to forge a personal or emotional connection. However, the emotional stiffness that is associated with hegemonic masculinity poses a conflict between manhood and homosocial relationships. Scott Kiesling labels the conflict between homosocial relationships and masculinity as a “male homosocial double bind” (Kiesling, 2005). Men want to create close friendships but there is an expectation to forgo intimacy. The conflict can also be understood as a “broken continuum between homosocial and homosexual” in male homosocial relationships (Sedgwick, 1985). The continuum is much more free-flowing for women compared to the “dichotomous opposition” of homosocial and homosexual relationship for men (Sedgwick, 1985). The act of saying the phrase “no homo” when two male friends act in a way that could be construed as homosexual illustrates that there are distinct boundaries drawn between two male friends; which supports the dichotomous opposition of homosociality and homosexuality in male friendships.

Despite the contradiction, there are instances where males have been able to develop close and intimate nonsexual relationships amidst a hegemonic masculine culture. For instance,

fraternities foster intimate relationships through their solidarity, displays of affection, and self-disclosure. In one interview, a fraternity member attested to the depths of self-disclosure when he said, “The things that I can tell my fraternity brothers I can’t tell my girlfriend” (Kiesling, 2005). Additionally, fraternity brothers broadcast their affection for each other in fraternity meetings to display their love for the brotherhood and in private situations when making up after an argument (Kiesling, 2005). The following quote from a fraternity member illustrates the affectionate nature of fraternities: “You’re not in love with your brothers as much as we are in love with our brothers” (Kiesling, 2005).

Another example of a homosocial relationship which contradicts hegemonic masculinity is the bromance relationship. A bromance is a nonsexual, close friendship between two males which accentuates intimacy and affection (Sargent, 2013). Bromances give space for intimate male friendships by crossing the boundaries of a stereotypical friendship. At the same time, bromance relationships bypass the straight panic phenomenon because often times the counterparts in a bromance are identified as heterosexual in society (Sedgwick, 1985). Straight panic is the stress attached to society’s perception of an individual’s sexuality and results in behavior that attempts to assert their heterosexuality (Sedgwick, 1985). The absence of straight panic in a bromance relationship allow the two males to display physical affection, such as long hugs or slaps on the butt, and discussion of intimate topics. Moreover, bromances give space for the emotional support that is similar to women’s same-sex friendships (Kaya et al., 2019).

Development of Friendship

Social Penetration Theory is a framework which emphasizes disclosure to explain relationship development. The Social Penetration Theory often illustrates interpersonal

relationships as peeling back layers of an onion until the core self is discovered. The breadth (amount of material discussed) and depth (degree of intimacy in the material) of self-disclosures determines the advancement to different layers (Hayes 1984). Reciprocity of disclosure in regards to degree of intimacy and amount of topics discussed also affects relationship development.

Altman and Taylor explicate four stages of the process of relationship development: orientation, exploratory affective exchange, full affective exchange, and stable exchange. Orientation is characterized by sharing surface level information or the outer layer of themselves (Taylor & Altman 1987). The orientation phase would include an individual's occupation or hometown. Next, the exploratory affective exchange phase expands upon the breadth of disclosure while remaining on a public level (Taylor & Altman, 1987). These topics might range from political opinions to favorite sports teams. The third stage, full affective exchange, is comprised of an increase of depth in the conversations and would include more personal information (Taylor & Altman 1987). The fourth and last stage, stable exchange, represents conversations with openness, breadth, and depth (Taylor & Altman 1987). The stable exchange phase is where individuals find the core self. The Social Penetration Theory also accounts for social depenetration where a relationship deteriorates; thus, the openness, breadth, and depth declines.

The Power of Media

The Social Cognitive Theory assumes that observed behavior informs individuals and fosters similar behaviors and beliefs (Brown, 2002). The likelihood of modeling is increased when the observed behaviors have positive outcomes and when those performing the acts are

attractive (Bandura, 1986). The Social Cognitive Theory displays the power media depictions have in regards to influencing watcher's behavior and beliefs. Media is a viable platform to illustrate behavior and ideas to then influence behavior and beliefs on large scale (Bandura, 1986). The power of media's influence in behavior change is demonstrated in the rise of "influencers" on Youtube, Instagram, Twitter, ect. Essentially, companies are relying on the influencer to display themselves using their product and in turn they hope that potential customers are willing to model the influencer's act and buy the product. Under a similar assumption, the media can create social change through their depictions of social constructions (Bryant & Zillmann, 2002).

Research Goals

The Social Cognitive Theory affirms that people tend to gain knowledge on how to behave through observation, imitation and modeling (Bandura, 1994). Consequently, media's relationship between modeled and learned behavior creates an opportunity to reconstruct dogmas within society. There has been recent research in Hollywood's decision to display new constructions of masculinity through comedic "bromance" relationships depicted in romantic comedies (Alberti 2013; Rennett, 2015; Sargent, 2013). However, there has been little to no research conducted on bromance relationship in the realm of unscripted reality television shows. The purpose of this study is to expand our knowledge on the dynamics of bromance relationships in the media by focusing on the reality television show, *Jersey Shore*. This paper highlights the challenges that the development and maintenance of bromance relationships are often accustomed to through the lens of the Social Penetration Theory. On a grander scale, I used the

Social Cognitive Theory and its emphasis on observational learning to explore whether bromance relationships change constructions of masculinity.

Method

I selected the reality television show, *Jersey Shore*, for analysis because of the pop culture significance and large following. *Jersey Shore* dominated Thursday night television and had a demographic between twelve and thirty-four years old (Thompson & Mittell, 2013). I selected one episode from each season, which totaled to six analyzed episodes. *Jersey Shore* ran from 2009 to 2012 and, in that time frame, released 6 seasons and 71 episodes. Each episode is about 45 minutes long. I also viewed two promotional videos MTV released that specifically focus on Pauly D and Vinny's relationship and an MTV sponsored pop quiz on how well Pauly D and Vinny know each other. The promotional videos included clips from the original show, *Jersey Shore*, and the reboot, *Jersey Shore: Family Vacation*. I also researched how MTV has used the two men's bromance as a marketing tactic through articles, tweets, and public perception.

In my analysis, I focused on Pauly and Vinny's interactions. I watched the episodes twice and short videos three times. I frequently noted key moments and went back to rewatch those moments. Throughout my analysis procedure I relied on the "Friend Observation Checklist (FOC)" which was developed by Robert B. Hayes (Hayes, 1984). Hayes developed the FOC with inspiration from the Social Penetration Theory to account for the gradual development of friendship through the breadth and depth of exchanges. He identified a gap in research of friendship development in areas other than self-disclosure. The FOC accounts for four areas of behavior: "companionship, consideration, communication (or self-disclosure), and affection"

(Hayes, 1984). Companionship refers to spending time with one another. Consideration describes an individual's concern for another's well being. Communication or self-disclosure represents the amount of information an individual divulges about oneself. Lastly, affection represents the expression of an "emotional bond" between two friends (Hayes, 1984). The aforementioned categories were developed to include a comprehensive inventory of friendship behaviors and to classify behaviors using the depth and breadth structure.

Thematic Analysis

Overview

The themes of my analysis emerged from the contradictions within a homosocial relationship between the four identified categories of friendship behavior and constructions of masculinity. For each component of a friendship, there are corresponding contradictions adapted from gendered stereotypes. Constructions of masculinity expect men to forgo intimacy while developing a relationship; which directly contradicts with the social penetration theory which holds that self-disclosure or intimacy is what advances a relationship. For instance, companionship contradicts with independence, consideration with competitiveness, and self disclosure and affection with emotional restrictiveness. Despite the contradiction, Vinny and Pauly's relationship has bypassed many obstacles of homosocial relationships in men such as straight panic and the male homosocial double bind. The most prominent tactic that the two friends used to overcome straight panic and the male homosocial double bind is humor.

Obstacles and all, Pauly and Vinny's displays of companionship, consideration, self-disclosure, and affection point to their relationship being in the final stage of the social

penetration theory: stable exchange. In other words, the two men have peeled back the metaphorical onion and reached each other's core self.

MTV has utilized Pauly and Vinny's unique bromance as a marketing tactic for their shows and MTV brand. The pop culture significance of Pauly and Vinny's friendship has popularized the term bromance. Viewers have responded with admiration and even a bit of envy that Pauly and Vinny have formed such a meaningful connection. Thus, I would argue that MTV's content, as a contributor to media, supports the reconstruction of masculinity to include homosocial intimacy. Given the positive reaction to Pauly and Vinny's bromance and the maintenance of their manhood in the eyes of the public, their bromance is content which can be observed and modeled by viewers.

Companionship

Companionship, the enjoyment of one's interactions with another, is the base of any friendship and studies show companionship is associated with greater well-being (Newsom et al., 2005). The constructions of masculinity that a man must be independent contradicts the universal characteristics of a homosocial relationship of companionship. However, from the start of *Jersey Shore*, Vinny and Pauly D have speed up their relationship development through the companionship accompanied with being roommates for consecutive summers. During the show, Pauly and Vinny were inseparable while they lived together; their friendship became imbedded into their routine of the sacred regimen, 'G.T.L.' or 'gym, tan, laundry.' But, the construction of masculinity that a man must be independent contradicts with the benefits of companionship attributed to a relationship. Nevertheless, Vinny and Pauly do not hide the comfort and enjoyment that they found in each other's company. Vinny emphasizes the companionship

accompanied with being roommates for the summer in the following quote: “When you find someone who you can get along and you realize that and you can live with them, you form a little relationship” (MTV, 2018).

The interactions between Pauly and Vinny’s that are depicted on the show are often characterized by light-hearted comedic relief that offers an escape from the heavy drama of other couples in the show. Their companionship through forming an alliance in the famous prank wars in the house is a prime example that brought Vinny and Paul closer together. One day Vinny and Pauly decided to prank one of their roommates, Deanna, by removing photos of Deanna and her boyfriend from her room and replacing them with intimate photos of Vinny and Pauly. These replacement photos consisted of kissing each other on the cheek and intimate eyestares. The prank itself acted as an amusing activity for Vinny and Pauly because they had to go to the boardwalk and take many pictures in a photo booth. But, their adventure also rejected the notion of straight panic that many homosocial friendships fall victim to. As previously mentioned, straight panic is the concern of heterosexual men that their behavior will be perceived as homosexual (Sedgwick, 1985). In this case and many other cases, Vinny and Pauly used humor and pranks as a tactic to dismiss the possible concern that viewers will perceive the two men as having homosexual tendencies.

Furthermore, the dependency of Pauly and Vinny’s companionship that they develop over the summers is depicted each time they say goodbye. When each summer winds down, Pauly and Vinny have a very difficult time saying goodbye to each other. In an MTV montage of their relationship, Vinny told Pauly: “the hardest part is leaving you” (MTV, 2018).

Consideration

Consideration, the act of caring about another person, is an essential attribute of a relationship. The stereotypical constructions of masculinity hold that a man should favor competition over displaying signs of warmth or tender emotions, like consideration. However, Vinny and Pauly regularly exhibit behaviors of consideration for one another. Pauly and Vinny often boost each other's self-esteem with their support in a culture that emphasizes appearances. For example, when Vinny got his ears pierced, Pauly repeatedly exclaimed how “fresh and gangsta” Vinny now looked. In addition, the two friends would hype each other up before going out to the club as they repeatedly yelled “t-shirt time” as they got ready.

Another example of consideration displayed in the two friend's relationship is on one of the first nights Pauly and Vinny went to the club, a random guy began to cause trouble with Vinny. In response, Pauly punched the trouble-maker and he said, “from that moment on he was like family to me” (MTV Jersey Shore, 2018). Pauly's aggressive response adheres to stereotypes of men that a man is aggressive and overly protective. However, his response also conveys that there are positive traits of masculinity such as being protective. Additionally, Pauly makes the distinction that their relationship is closer to a brotherhood than lovers.

A further example that displays the consideration that surrounds Vinny and Pauly's relationship is when Pauly tried to cheer up Vinny during a stressful time. Pauly treated him to a bag of gym goodies and a guy day, which consisted of manicures and pedicures. The fact that their guy day consisted of pampering activities, which are usually associated with women displays the general rejection of certain male stereotypes. Importantly, Pauly's efforts display the consideration and emotional support that characterizes their relationship.

Self-Disclosure and Affection

Another trait of masculinity that contradicts with the development and maintenance of homosocial relationships is emotional restrictiveness or the notion that men don't talk about or express feelings. However, the key tenant of Social Penetration Theory, self-disclosure, and displays of affection are most apparent in Vinny and Pauly's relationship. The two friends frequently communicate the depth of their affection for each other, an act which most men would ignore. MTV released a promotional video from the reboot, *Jersey Shore: Family Vacation*, which illustrated Vinny and Pauly's "brommitment" ceremony in Las Vegas. The clip showed Vinny walking down the aisle wearing a wedding veil, while Pauly waited next to an Elvis impersonator as he exclaimed how beautiful Vinny looked. The two best friends exchanged vows before giving each other a bear hug to seal the deal. Pauly revealed his confidence that Vinny and him would have a bromance the moment he met Vinny and his family. Vinny's "brommitment" vows expressed the continuity of their bromance by pronouncing he wants to do "t-shirt time" forever. Pauly and Vinny's "brommitment" ceremony and relationship as a whole does not forgo the intimacy that most male friendships abandon.

Constructions of masculinity often communicate that when men show affection for other men they are risking their heterosexual status. Thereby, they are risking their manhood because under this set of ideas, homosexuals are not considered masculine. This emotional screen to avoid straight panic can have negative health effects because, as previously mentioned, studies show that emotional restrictiveness is correlated with a lower well-being and mental health (Kaya et al., 2019). However, Vinny and Pauly overcame the homosocial double bind because they did not abandon the intimacy necessary for relationship development for fear of straight panic. Pauly and Vinny often used humor within in their displays of affection to quash the

homosocial double bind. In one episode, Vinny got into Pauly's bed and they both made sexually insinuating jokes in front of their roommate, Deanna. In another episode, Pauly left early in the morning and went into Vinny's room to give him a kiss on the cheek and they exchanged I love yous.

In addition to depth of self-disclosure, Pauly and Vinny also show a great deal of breadth of self-disclosure through the amount of random information they know about each other. In an interview pop quiz, testing how well the best friends know each other, Pauly and Vinny passed with flying colors. They knew each other's quirky personal information from favorite Sunday dinner dish to the go-to gym pose.

MTV's Marketing Tool

One of the research goals in this paper is to understand how the uptick in the depiction of intimate homosocial relationships in the media affects public perception and constructions of masculinity. As mentioned, the Social Cognitive Theory holds that the media has the power to influence whether certain beliefs and behaviors are adopted by the observer. Additionally, Bandura proposed that the likelihood of modeling is heightened when those performing the acts are attractive (Bandura, 1986). Therefore, it is necessary to research how MTV has marketed Vinny and Pauly's bromance to viewers and the public perception of their relationship.

MTV has frequently used Vinny and Pauly's bromance as a marketing tool for the Jersey Shore brand; including the original *Jersey Shore* and the reboots, *Jersey Shore: Family Vacation* and *Jersey Shore: Family Vacation Part 2*. MTV released articles such as "The 5 Biggest Moments from Vinny and Pauly's Bromance," "MTV Twitter Roundup: Pauly and Vinny's Bromance is a Work of Art," "Vinny and Pauly Take their Bromance to a Whole 'Nother Level,"

and “The Most Bromantic Moments Vinny and Pauly D Have Shared on *Family Vacation*.” MTV has also released a promotional video called, “9 Times Vinny & Pauly D Proved Their Bromance is Real” in 2018 to promote the reboot show. Furthermore, the pair has gotten a spin-off television show, *A Double Shot At Love*, that MTV created in response to the viewers’ appeal for Pauly and Vinny’s long lasting friendship. MTV’s official *Jersey Shore* twitter account tweeted, “You asked for it, and it’s happening!!! Your favorite bromance is getting a show, A Double Shot At Love with DJ Pauly D & Vinny! 🙌🙌” (MTV Jersey Shore, 2019).

The public response to Pauly and Vinny’s friendship has been positive and their bromance has been adopted into pop culture. Pauly and Vinny have remained well liked and popular; as of June 2019, Pauly D has 3.8 million Instagram followers and Vinny has 3.2 million Instagram followers. This would suggest viewers find Pauly and Vinny attractive and are, therefore, more likely to model their behavior. Moreover, Vinny and Pauly have even earned a definition on Urban Dictionary, a dictionary for pop culture and slang. The top definition for Vinny and Pauly D is: “The best romance to every hit daytime television” (Urban Dictionary, 2012). Furthermore, there are thousands of tweets on Twitter expressing their love and envy of Pauly and Vinny’s bromance; from making them “bromance goals” to wishing for a bromance like theirs.

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